The one-page Homelab checklist

Twelve checks taken from the chapter checklists in the Homelab the Right Way books. Tick each box once it's true for your lab.

Backups

- [ ] Set ONE Proxmox backup job to “All guests” with excludes, instead of a hand-picked list. A new VM added last week is already covered; a list you have to remember to edit is how new guests silently go unbacked.
  Homelab the Right Way, ch. 1 checklist: backups
- [ ] Make sure the newest backup of every guest is less than 48 hours old, and that failure notifications land in a mailbox you actually read. A job that quietly stops is worse than no job, because you think you're covered.
  Homelab the Right Way, ch. 1 checklist: backups
- [ ] Do one test restore per quarter and write the date down. A backup you have never restored is a hope, not a backup.
  Homelab the Right Way, ch. 1 checklist: backups
- [ ] Point vzdump at a backup storage that is NOT the host's own disk, with retention set on the storage. Use snapshot mode, ZSTD, a nightly schedule, and have the guest agent running in every VM.
  Never Lose Your Data, ch. 2 checklist: vzdump
- [ ] Every restore drill goes to a NEW VM ID with the network unplugged, then gets destroyed. That way a drill can never clobber the running guest or fight it for an IP.
  Never Lose Your Data, ch. 7 checklist: restore testing

Hosts & cluster

- [ ] Running two Proxmox nodes? Put a QDevice on separate hardware (a Pi or any always-on box that isn't a cluster node). Then check that pvecm status shows the vote count you expect.
  Homelab the Right Way, ch. 2 checklist: cluster
- [ ] On your Docker host VM, mount the data disk by label with nofail. A disk mounted by /dev/sdX can swap names after a reboot, and nofail keeps the VM booting even if the drive is missing.
  Self-Host Your Life, ch. 1 checklist: foundation
- [ ] Before a Home Assistant core update, take a backup and a Proxmox snapshot (qm snapshot 120 pre-update), update one layer at a time (core, then add-ons, then HACS, then the OS), and delete the snapshot a week later.
  Automations That Just Work, Chapter 8

Network & remote access

- [ ] Before you disable OPNsense's anti-lockout rule, add your own pass rule for your admin machines to the firewall's web port and test it. The anti-lockout rule has done its job only once your own rule works.
  Lock Down Your Home Network, Chapter 2
- [ ] A plain-DNS redirect on port 53 cannot catch DNS over TLS. Block port 853 outbound from every internal network, and let only the firewall's own resolver use it upstream.
  Lock Down Your Home Network, Chapter 7
- [ ] For remote access, run Tailscale on the server as a subnet router and disable key expiry for that node. If you forward any port at all, make it 443 to the reverse proxy and nothing else.
  Self-Host Your Life, ch. 5 checklist: remote access

Storage

- [ ] Run zpool status -x right now. Anything other than "all pools are healthy" means a vdev has lost redundancy, and the clock is running.
  Store It Right, Chapter 7

More every Sunday: the free weekly email at chartmann1590.github.io/homelab-the-right-way/newsletter/ . The full books (each with a free sample) are at payhip.com/HomelabtheRightWay . Written with AI help, based on the Homelab the Right Way books. Check commands against your own setup before running them.